

Day 3 — Product Design & UX Principles for TPMs

Activity packet for participant triads. Today's job: equip you to partner credibly with design — to spot UX failures, name them in the right vocabulary, and ship 3 design principles your squad can hold the line on.

Where we are in the week

Days 1–2 produced a Metrics Tier Sheet and a defensible North Star. Today the triads zoom into the **product surface** — the actual screens, flows, and moments where the strategy meets the user.

A TPM is not a designer. But a TPM who cannot tell a designer why a UX choice matters, in design vocabulary, will lose every trade-off conversation. That's today's muscle.

Inputs

- The triad's NS and Tier Sheet (from Days 1–2)
 - One product surface (FieldPulse mobile, FieldPulse web, or a competitor like Housecall Pro / ServiceTitan) — chosen by the triad before today
 - The **UX Heuristics Card** (handout)
 - The **A11y Floor Checklist** (handout)
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The UX Heuristics Card (today's reference)

We use Nielsen's 10 heuristics as the shared vocabulary, plus three TPM-specific lenses we add on top.

Nielsen's 10 (abbreviated):

1. Visibility of system status
2. Match between system and real world
3. User control and freedom (undo)
4. Consistency and standards
5. Error prevention
6. Recognition rather than recall
7. Flexibility and efficiency of use
8. Aesthetic and minimalist design
9. Help users recognize, diagnose, recover from errors
10. Help and documentation

TPM-specific lenses (added today):

11. **Time-to-first-value:** can a new user produce a useful result in their first session?
12. **Failure-mode dignity:** how does the product behave when the network drops, the data is wrong, or the user is rushed?

13. **Power-user respect:** does the product reward repeat use with shortcuts, or punish it with the same friction every time?
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Activity 1 — Heuristic Hunt

Format: Triad • 35 min • Block 1

Purpose

Calibrate the room on the Nielsen 10 by hunting violations in a live product before they audit their own.

Setup

Each triad uses the **same** product (we recommend a B2B SaaS the cohort doesn't already use — e.g., a niche CRM trial). The triad walks through one core flow (signup → first action → return).

The protocol

1. Each triad member silently captures **3 heuristic violations** (5 min)
2. Triad pools and de-dupes (15 min)
3. Triad picks the **single most painful** violation and the **single most subtle** one (10 min)
4. Prepare a 60-second readout (5 min)

Readout (60 sec per triad)

"The most painful violation we found was [X]. The most subtle was [Y] — we almost missed it because [reason]."

Deliverable

A short list per triad: 3+ heuristic violations with the heuristic number named, plus one "most painful" and one "most subtle" call.

Activity 2 — A11y Floor Audit

Format: Triad • 40 min • Block 2

Purpose

TPMs at most companies inherit accessibility debt. Today we install the **non-negotiable floor** — the small set of checks a TPM should run before *any* PRD ships.

The A11y Floor Checklist (8 items)

CHECK	TOOL	WHAT "FAIL" LOOKS LIKE
All interactive elements keyboard-focusable	Tab through the page	Focus disappears or skips elements
Visible focus indicator	Tab through the page	No outline or visible state when focused
Color contrast 4.5:1 (text), 3:1 (large text)	Browser devtools / WebAIM	Light gray on white, blue-on-blue
Form fields have associated labels	Screen reader / inspect	"Edit text, blank" announced
Images have alt text	View source	<code></code> on meaningful images
Page has a logical heading hierarchy	Outline tool	Jumps from <code><h1></code> to <code><h4></code>
Error messages identify the field	Submit a broken form	"Error" with no field reference
Touch targets ≥ 44 px on mobile	DevTools mobile view	Buttons too small to tap reliably

Triad protocol

1. Open the FieldPulse mobile (or chosen surface) on each member's device
2. Each member runs **3 of the 8 checks** (assign so all 8 are covered, plus one overlap)
3. Pool findings; for each fail, identify which UX heuristic is also being violated
4. Output: a one-page **A11y Floor Audit** for the chosen surface

Why TPMs care

Accessibility is a regulatory floor (ADA / Section 508 / EAA), an SEO floor, and a usability ceiling — fixes for keyboard-focus often fix mouse-user errors too. This audit is the kind of artifact TPMs are expected to surface unsolicited.

Deliverable

A one-page A11y Floor Audit per triad: each of the 8 checks rated pass/partial/fail with a heuristic cross-link for every fail.

Activity 3 — Heuristic Audit of Your Triad's Surface

Format: Triad • 40 min • Block 3

Purpose

Apply the calibrated eye from Activity 1 + the floor from Activity 2 to the triad's chosen product surface.

Setup

Each triad opens its chosen flow (FieldPulse mobile, web, or competitor). All three triad members need access.

Steps

1. **Solo walk-through (10 min).** Each member captures 3+ findings independently.
2. **Pool + score severity (15 min).** Consolidate findings; assign 1–5 severity per the guide.

3. **Write up (10 min).** Fill the template — top 3 violations, top 3 strengths, A11y result, TPM lenses.
4. **Question for design (5 min).** Name the one question that only the design team can answer.

The audit template

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# UX Audit: <Product surface>
**Auditor triad:** <names>
**Flow audited:** <e.g., "Dispatcher first-time reconcile flow">

## Top 3 violations
| # | Heuristic | What we observed | Why it matters | Severity (1-5) |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | ... | ... | ... | ... |
| 2 | ... | ... | ... | ... |
| 3 | ... | ... | ... | ... |

## Top 3 strengths
> Things this product does *better than the average B2B SaaS*. Name and praise.

## A11y floor result
> Pass / Partial / Fail (per A11y Floor Checklist). List failed checks.

## TPM lens findings (Heuristics 11-13)
- **Time-to-first-value:** ...
- **Failure-mode dignity:** ...
- **Power-user respect:** ...

## One question we cannot answer without the design team
> ...
```

Severity scoring guide

SCORE	MEANING
5	Causes user task failure or data loss
4	Causes recurring frustration that users work around
3	Slows users down; they don't notice but a stopwatch would
2	Cosmetic; affects trust
1	Edge case

Deliverable

A completed UX Audit per triad covering top 3 violations (severity-scored), top 3 strengths, A11y result, TPM lens findings, and one design-only question.

Activity 4 — From Audit to Design Principles

Format: Triad • 45 min + Readouts • Block 4

Purpose

Convert the audit findings into **3 design principles** the squad can hold the line on across PRDs. This is the day's keeper artifact.

Setup

Each triad has its completed UX Audit from Activity 3 and a way to write the principle cards (paper or digital).

Steps

What a design principle looks like

A good design principle is:

- A **statement**, not a feature
- **Decision-making** — it tells you what to choose when two options compete
- Phrased in the **product's voice**, not the framework's
- **Memorable** — short enough that an engineer would quote it back

Examples (good and bad)

GOOD	WHY	BAD	WHY
"If a dispatcher can't recover from a mis-tap in 1 second, we built it wrong."	Decision-making, specific, memorable	"Be user-friendly"	Vacuous
"Show the network state on every screen — assume connectivity is broken."	Drives concrete choices	"Use Material Design"	A toolkit, not a principle
"Power users get keyboard shortcuts. New users get them visible too."	Tension named and resolved	"Be consistent"	True but not actionable

Triad protocol

1. **Cluster audit findings** (10 min). Group your findings into themes — each theme suggests a principle.
2. **Draft 5 candidate principles** (15 min). Some will be bad. That's fine.
3. **Cull to 3** (10 min). Test each: does it tell us what to choose when two options compete?
4. **Write the principle card** (10 min). Each principle gets one line + one example of a decision it would force.

Readout structure (90 seconds per triad)

1. "Our top audit finding was [X], severity [N]."
2. "The 3 principles we'd hold the squad to are: [P1], [P2], [P3]."
3. "The principle that would cause the most disagreement with our designers is [P_x] because [why]."

Deliverable

A 3-Principle Card per triad: each principle as one line + one decision it would force.

End-of-day checkpoint

Each triad leaves the day with:

- ✓ A heuristic-violation finding from Activity 1 (live calibration)
- ✓ An A11y Floor Audit for one surface
- ✓ A UX Audit (top 3 violations + 3 strengths + TPM lenses)
- ✓ **Three design principles** the squad would hold the line on
- ✓ At least one open question for the design team